

have understood the elevated risks of having conditions like obesity, diabetes, etc. Governments across the world are also creating pathways for early interventions because chronic disease burden has a significant economic impact,” says Chandan.

The rapid pace of adoption of wearable devices such as fitness trackers and smartwatches is also contributing to this trend. Fitness technology start-ups such as GO-Qii are driving growth in preventive healthcare by unlocking the power of consumers’ health and lifestyle data. Next step: a health Metaverse, which is likely to transform digital health into an immersive space, says Vishal Gondal, Founder & CEO of GOQii: “Health Metaverse will empower players in the virtual as well as the physical world. This will be done by providing tokens or rewards for adopting a healthy lifestyle.”

Apart from gadgets, powering the shift towards preventive healthcare are technologies such as cloud computing. The start-ups are leveraging cloud computing to build and scale their applications, which generate, digitise and analyse vast amounts of health data using advanced technologies such as internet of things (IoT), data analytics, artificial intelligence (AI) and machine learning (ML). The RedSeer report says that over 30 per cent of the top 40 funded preventive healthtech start-ups leverage AI/ML for use cases such as medical image analysis, document extraction, chatbots, personalisation, and health risk prediction.

For example, HealthifyMe’s latest offering, HealthifyPro, predicts glucose values without using a physical device. Instead, it leverages Amazon SageMaker, a cloud ML platform, which helps build, train and deploy ML models for any use case with fully managed infrastructure, tools, and workflows. HealthifyPro also uses other AWS services such as Amazon OpenSearch, Amazon Elastic Container Service and Amazon RDS to deliver superior health outcomes.



“The curative healthcare market is going to struggle to keep up with the rise of chronic diseases. So, turning to preventive healthcare is inevitable and the need of the hour”

Dr Hema Venkataraman
MEDICAL ADVISOR-NEW
OFFERINGS, PRACTO



“Healthtech start-ups can certainly play a role in mitigating the disease burden in the country”

Dr Anoop Misra
CHAIRMAN, FORTIS-C-DOC
HOSPITAL, NEW DELHI

“We work closely with many founders to provide healthtech start-ups the technology foundation they need to bring their vision to life,” says Kumara Raghavan, Head-AWS Startups India at Amazon Internet Services. “Healthtech start-ups are tapping into the preventive health opportunity across segments such as nutrition management, condition management, lifestyle monitoring, health check-ups, as well as mental and physical wellness.”

Digital technology is also helping diagnostics start-ups attract customers for early, preventive health check-ups. “Early detection and screening technologies make up a sizeable portion of preventive healthcare,” says Dheeraj Jain, Founder of Redcliffe Labs, an omnichannel diagnostics chain. “Due to the precision and accessibility of cutting-edge diagnostic procedures, this market segment has attracted the greatest share. On this front, the preventive healthcare market is a lucrative option for expansion.”

Not surprisingly, venture capital is rushing in to fund preventive healthtech start-ups. For instance, Chiratae Ventures, a tech VC firm, has invested over \$110 million across 18 start-ups, including Cult.fit, HealthifyMe, Redcliffe Labs, Smiles.ai and several others. Overall, funding in healthtech start-ups has risen a whopping 432 per cent to \$2.9 billion in 2021 from \$543.4 million in 2020, as per data from Tracxn. Such start-ups have raised \$1.3 billion so far in 2022. “The growing concern over the next Covid wave, which has already begun spreading globally, will increase the user base of such start-ups in the coming months,” says Neha Singh, Co-founder of Tracxn.

That is probably a good thing. As the start-ups increase their reach, and the scale of their preventive outcomes rises over time, they might actually help reduce the burden of chronic diseases in the country. **BT**

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